

Research Interests

- Responsible and ethical AI, and sociotechnical approaches to model design
- Pluralistic and positive AI alignment: Language technologies that represent diverse human perspectives and support human flourishing
- Alignment operationalization and objective trade-offs; sociotechnical evaluation and benchmarking
- Sociotechnical failures: persuasion, offensive language, stereotypes, and toxicity in LLMs

Education

University of Stuttgart - Institute for Natural Language Processing (IMS)

Stuttgart, Germany

PH.D. IN COMPUTER SCIENCE / NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING

ADVISORS: AGNIESZKA FALEŃSKA, SEBASTIAN PADÓ

2023 - present

DISSERTATION: ALIGNMENT GAPS: NORMATIVE FOUNDATIONS, MODELING CHALLENGES, AND THE DOWNSTREAM EFFECTS OF PREFERENCE LEARNING

University of Stuttgart - Institute for Natural Language Processing (IMS)

Stuttgart, Germany

M.SC. IN COMPUTATIONAL LINGUISTICS

ADVISOR: THANG VU

2020 - 2023

THESIS: PROMPT-BASED LEARNING FOR OPEN-DOMAIN VISUAL QUESTION ANSWERING

Experience

Institute for Natural Language Processing (IMS), University of Stuttgart

Stuttgart, Germany

DOCTORAL RESEARCHER

2023 - present

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment: developing language technologies that represent diverse human perspectives and support human flourishing
- Sociotechnical benchmarking/evaluation of LLMs: pluralistic gaps, persuasion and argumentation, (non-)offensive speech identification, and reward-model preferences
- Lecturer for MSc-level courses: Advanced Deep Learning in Speech and Language Processing, Spoken Dialog Systems, Advanced Topics in LLM Interpretability)
- MSc thesis supervision

Institute for Language, Cognition and Computation (ILCC), School of Informatics, University of Edinburgh

Edinburgh, UK

VISITING RESEARCHER, HOST: BJÖRN ROSS

Aug 2026 - present: Oct 2026

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment, human-label variation, and responsible and ethical NLP

Interaction Lab, Heriot-Watt University

Edinburgh, UK

VISITING RESEARCHER, HOST: GAVIN ABERCROMBIE

Aug 2026 - present: Oct 2026

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment and human-label variation

MilaNLP Lab, Bocconi University

Milan, Italy

VISITING RESEARCHER, HOST: DIRK HOVY

May 2026 - Jul 2026

- Research on pluralistic AI alignment and human-label variation

Institute for Natural Language Processing (IMS), University of Stuttgart

Stuttgart, Germany

GRADUATE STUDENT ASSISTANT, ADVISOR: THANG VU

Jun 2022 - May 2023

- Research on clarifying questions in dialog systems
- Research on Image-Text Matching in Vision and Language (HNC)
- Teaching assistant for Advanced Deep Learning in Speech and Language Processing

Mercedes-Benz AG

Sindelfingen, Germany

RESEARCH INTERN, ADVISOR: STEFAN ULTES

Feb 2022 - Jun 2022

- Research on dialog systems (product: Hey Mercedes voice assistant)

- Research on speech synthesis for academic and industry applications

Publications

Conference Articles

A Systematic Analysis of Linguistic Features in AI-Generated Text Detection Across Domains and Models

2026

YASSIR EL ATTAR, **ESRA DÖNMEZ**, MAXIMILIAN MAURER, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

Accepted to the Findings of

ARXIV:2606.04177

AACL-IJCNLP'26

AI Argues Differently: Distinct Argumentative and Linguistic Patterns of LLMs in Persuasive Contexts

2025

ESRA DÖNMEZ^{*}, MAXIMILIAN MAURER^{*}, GABRIELLA LAPESA, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 2025 CONFERENCE ON EMPIRICAL METHODS IN NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING (EMNLP), SUZHOU, CHINA

“I understand your perspective”: LLM Persuasion through the Lens of Communicative Action Theory

2025

ESRA DÖNMEZ AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

FINDINGS OF THE ASSOCIATION FOR COMPUTATIONAL LINGUISTICS: ACL 2025, VIENNA, AUSTRIA

Please note that I'm just an AI: Analysis of Behavior Patterns of LLMs in (Non-)offensive Speech Identification

2024

ESRA DÖNMEZ, THANG VU, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 2024 CONFERENCE ON EMPIRICAL METHODS IN NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING (EMNLP), MIAMI, FLORIDA, USA

HNC: Leveraging Hard Negative Captions towards Models with Fine-Grained Visual-Linguistic Comprehension Capabilities

2023

ESRA DÖNMEZ^{*}, PASCAL TILLI^{*}, HSIU-YU YANG^{*}, THANG VU, AND CARINA SILBERER.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 27TH CONFERENCE ON COMPUTATIONAL NATURAL LANGUAGE LEARNING (CONLL), SINGAPORE

Peer-Reviewed Workshop Articles

SEAL: SocioEconomic Alignment in LLMs

2026

ELISA BASSIGNANA^{*}, LORENA CALVO-BARTOLOMÉ^{*}, **ESRA DÖNMEZ**^{*}, AND MARLENE LUTZ^{*}, ARIANNA MUTI^{*}, VERA NEPLENBROEK^{*}, DONYA ROEIN^{*}

PROCEEDINGS OF THE FIFTH WORKSHOP ON NLP FOR POSITIVE IMPACT (NLP4PI), BUDAPEST, HUNGARY

Leveraging Comparable Toxicity Lexicons in Prompt Instructions for Multilingual Text Detoxification

2026

YASSIR EL ATTAR, **ESRA DÖNMEZ**, NINA K. OHLENDORF, AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE 19TH WORKSHOP ON BUILDING AND USING COMPARABLE CORPORA (BUCC), PALMA DE MALLORCA, SPAIN

Preprints

Structuring the Space of Sociotechnical Alignment

2026

ESRA DÖNMEZ AND AGNIESZKA FALENSKA.

ARXIV:2607.01250

Under review

Better Reward Models Are Not Less Biased Ones: Social Alignment Beyond Standard Reward Benchmarks

2026

GAYANE GHAZARYAN AND **ESRA DÖNMEZ**.

ARXIV:2605.05003

Under review

Predicting Objective Conflict and Covering Trade-offs in Steerable Pluralistic Alignment

2026

DAVID TSOI AND **ESRA DÖNMEZ**.

Under review

Teaching

Inside Transformers: Advanced Topics in LLM Interpretability

Stuttgart, Germany

UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — CO-LECTURER

Summer 2026

- Seminar on mechanistic interpretability — probing, causal tracing, sparse autoencoders — and its application to unlearning, steering, and safety.

Advanced Deep Learning in Speech and Language Processing	Stuttgart, Germany
UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — CO-LECTURER	Winter 2023/24
Spoken Dialogue Systems	Stuttgart, Germany
UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — CO-LECTURER	Winter 2023/24
Advanced Deep Learning in Speech and Language Processing	Stuttgart, Germany
UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART, IMS — TEACHING ASSISTANT	Winter 2022/23, Summer 2023

Academic Service

Finding Your Path: Honest Conversations on Early Career Paths in NLP	Budapest, Hungary
CO-ORGANIZER, BOF @EMNLP’26	2026
CSS Workshop: AI and Society	Stuttgart, Germany
CO-ORGANIZER, UNIVERSITY OF STUTTGART	2026
Brought together researchers from diverse NLP and CSS backgrounds to explore how computational approaches can support the study of social, cultural and institutional questions about AI.	
KnitTogether’25	Wildhaus, Switzerland
CO-ORGANIZER, 1ST EUROPEAN CL RESEARCH SUMMIT FOR JUNIOR RESEARCHERS	2025
Brought together 25 early-career researchers for a week-long summit on <i>Bias in NLP and its Societal Impacts</i>.	

Reviewing

CONFERENCE
ACL Rolling Review (ARR, 2023-2026), Conference on Computational Natural Language Learning (CoNLL, 2023), Language Resources and Evaluation Conference (LREC, 2024-2026), International Conference on Computational Linguistics (COLING, 2024-2026), Konferenz zur Verarbeitung natürlicher Sprache (KONVENS, 2026)
WORKSHOP
EACL Student Research Workshop (EACL SRW, 2025, 2026), Identity-Aware AI (2026), Perspectivist Approaches to NLP (NLPerspectives, 2026)
ETHICS REVIEW
ACL Rolling Review (ARR, 2025-2026)

Honors, Awards & Grants

2025	Outstanding Reviewer Award	IJCNLP-AAACL
2025	Outstanding Reviewer Award	EMNLP